

THE SELF FROM SOCIOLOGICAL PERSPECTIVES

Introduction

- **Concept:** Society significantly influences identity, thoughts, feelings, and actions from birth. The self can be understood as a puzzle where each piece (family, school, peers) represents a distinct social influence.

The Self as a Product of Modern Society Among Other Constructions

Charles Horton Cooley (1864–1929)

- **Overview:** American sociologist known for the “Looking-Glass Self” theory, which describes how self-image is shaped by how individuals think others see them (like seeing oneself reflected in the opinions and reactions of others).
- **Three Stages of the Looking-Glass Self:**
 1. *Imagination:* Envisioning how one appears to others (actions and behaviors).
 - *Example:* Joshua gives a presentation and imagines how classmates perceive his body language, tone, and content knowledge.
 2. *Interpretation:* Imagining how others judge those behaviors and reactions.
 - *Example:* Joshua imagines his classmates judge him as confident or nervous based on his presentation style.
 3. *Self-feeling:* Developing a self-concept based on feedback and perceived responses from others.
 - *Example:* Receiving compliments makes Joshua feel confident and capable, believing his classmates admire his skills.

George Herbert Mead (1863–1931) and the Social Self

Overview of Social Self Theory

- Formulated by American philosopher, sociologist, and psychologist George Herbert Mead.
- Asserts that personal identity is formed through social interaction, communication, and cultural expectations.

Key Aspects of Mead's Social Self Theory

- **The “I” and the “Me”:**
 - *The “I”:* The spontaneous aspect of the self that acts without considering social consequences.
 - *The “Me”:* The socialized aspect shaped by social expectations and norms; acts based on how others expect one to behave.
 - *Example:* Playing basketball where the “I” wants to win, and the “Me” follows the rules.
- **Role-Taking:**
 - *Explanation:* Developing a sense of self by imagining how others perceive us and adjusting behavior accordingly.
 - *Example:* Classroom presentation, imagining classmates’ reactions.

- **Significant Others and Generalized Others:**

- *Significant Others:* Individuals with direct influence on the person (e.g., parents). Children initially adopt only the roles of significant others.
- *Generalized Others:* Society's collective norms and expectations that individuals internalize. As children develop, they understand and adopt expectations of the entire group/society.
- *Example:* Parents' influence on self-concept (Significant Others); Society's norms (Generalized Others).

Stages of Self-Development (Mead)

1. **Preparatory Stage (Imitation):**

- *Age Range:* Birth to age two (2).
- *Description:* Children copy others but do not understand their actions, words, or tone of voice.
- *Example:* A baby imitating sounds made by parents, or a toddler copying an older sibling's actions like clapping or waving goodbye.

2. **Play Stage (Taking on Roles):**

- *Age Range:* Ages three (3) to six (6).
- *Description:* Children engage in imaginative play, pretending to take on roles (e.g., "mother" or "father" based on observation) without following rules in organized games.
- *Example:* A child playing house as the mother caring for toy children, or pretending to teach other kids or toys.

3. **Game Stage (Understanding Multiple Roles):**

- *Age Range:* Begins around age seven (7).
- *Description:* Children comprehend and follow game rules, take on roles independently, and consider others' perspectives simultaneously, forming the concept of the "generalized other."
- *Example:* A child playing baseball while understanding the pitcher, catcher, and outfielder roles at the same time, or participating in a school play while coordinating actions with crew members.

Conclusion of Mead's Theory

- Society shapes both mind and self. Minds rely on symbols delivered through language by society, making self-development a continuous, evolving process shaped by social interaction.